

Make the app calmer, one step at a time

A plain-language plan to reduce information overload without hiding source-backed facts, missing data, or the rule that fit is guidance - not a promise.

What this fixes

The audit found a real focus problem: people see too many messages and next steps at once. The first goal is not a redesign. It is to help a new student see one useful action, then reveal the next detail only when needed.

THE MAIN RULE

One screen should make one next action feel obvious. Everything else can stay available, but should be quieter, collapsed, or later.

WHAT MUST STAY

Keep source chips, “not published” labels, and the statement that fit is guidance. We will combine repeated warnings, never hide a real gap.

Recommended order

When	Focus
Week 1	Stop the counselor panel covering work
Week 1	Show one fit message on a university profile
Week 2	Show the next learning module first
Week 2	Make the dashboard point to one next action
Week 3	Tidy search and sign-up without losing evidence

Start with Step 1. Do not bundle every change into one release.

Step 1 - Let the page own the user's attention

The default-open counselor is useful, but it currently acts like a pop-up on top of the student's real task. On a phone it covers the intake, sign-in, dashboard, profile, and course actions.

1

Start the counselor closed on task screens

Goal: A student can see and use the main button on the page without first closing a chat.

Do: On Intake, Login, Dashboard, University Profile, and Learning Portal, show the small counselor button first. Open the full panel only after the student taps it. Keep the full counselor page open and easy to find.

Check: At 390px and 1440px, confirm the primary button is fully visible on each route. Test open, close, reopen, keyboard focus, and reduced-motion behavior.

Likely files: `app/src/components/CounselorWidget.tsx`; `app/src/App.tsx`; counselor widget tests.

2

Keep one calm safety message in development

Goal: Local development warnings do not compete with real product actions during review.

Do: Do not change the production safety rule. For local UX review, keep the development banner clearly separate from the user task and do not treat it as customer-facing clutter.

Check: Build the production app and verify the banner is absent there. In local review, verify it does not cover the page CTA.

Likely files: `app/src/components/EnvironmentBanner.tsx`; responsive visual checks.

WHY THIS COMES FIRST

It is the smallest high-impact change. It makes every other screen easier to judge and removes an actual mobile obstruction before we change any content.

Definition of done for Week 1

- The counselor still has an obvious launcher on every route.
- The full chat still works and keeps its conversation history.
- No main action is underneath the widget at 390px.
- No source, privacy, or counselor grounding rule is weakened.

Step 2 - Explain each missing thing once

The profile is where honest information becomes tiring. A student without an intake profile sees the same “fit is not calculated yet” message at the top, inside the report, and in the sidebar. Missing published data also appears as both a summary and many long mini-explanations.

3

Use one fit status before intake

Goal: The student sees one clear path: complete intake if they want a personal fit explanation.

Do: Keep the first “Complete intake to see fit” card. Remove the duplicate fit-unavailable block in Overview and the duplicate sidebar version. After intake, use the existing fit expander for the five reasons.

Check: Visit a profile signed out and after intake. There should be one fit message before intake and one expandable fit summary after intake.

Likely files: `app/src/screens/ProfileScreen.tsx`; `app/src/components/Trust.tsx`; profile tests.

4

Turn many gap paragraphs into details

Goal: A student can see that a fact is missing without reading the same explanation ten times.

Do: Keep the “published-data coverage” summary and keep “Not published” beside each field. Hide the long reason and suggested action under a small “Why unavailable?” control on individual fields.

Check: Use Harvard and a university with several missing figures. Confirm every missing fact still says it is unavailable and can reveal its reason, source context, and next action.

Likely files: `app/src/components/Trust.tsx`; `app/src/screens/ProfileScreen.tsx`; CostSummary-related tests.

5

Say the aid warning once

Goal: The student understands that published aid is not a personal offer without seeing the same warning in Costs and Scholarships.

Do: Place one short sentence next to the aid-adjusted cost: “Published aid is not your personal offer. Confirm eligibility and ask for an offer.” Let Scholarships link to this rule instead of repeating it.

Check: Check that the student can still find the source, the net-cost scenario, and the personal-offer warning without scrolling through duplicate text.

Likely files: `app/src/screens/ProfileScreen.tsx`; `app/src/components/CostSummary.tsx`.

HONESTY GUARDRAIL

Never replace an unknown value with a dash, zero, estimate, or silent blank. The change is to hide repeated explanation, not to hide the missing fact.

Step 3 - One clear next step

The Learning Portal shows 11 module cards at once. Ten say “locked” and repeat the same “Preview with warning” button. The dashboard also asks a new student to pick among several equal cards even though it already knows what should happen next.

6

Show one learning module first

Goal: A student sees “Start here” instead of ten unavailable alternatives.

Do: Keep the available or continue module as a full card. Put later modules in a collapsed “10 later modules” list with title and lock status. Let a student expand one when they intentionally want to preview it.

Check: On mobile and desktop, count one main learning action above the fold. Open a later module and confirm the sequence warning still appears before the content.

Likely files: app/src/screens/LearningScreens.tsx; app/src/learning/logic.ts; Learning Portal tests.

7

Let the dashboard lead with one next action

Goal: A new account is not asked to plan its whole future in one view.

Do: For the empty dashboard, show the first action - usually “Start intake” - and one sentence explaining why. Move the other two choices into a “More ways to continue” section below. Do not show zero-progress charts until there is recorded activity.

Check: Test a signed-in account with no profile, no saves, and no learning activity. There should be one primary action and no invented progress numbers.

Likely files: app/src/screens/DashboardScreen.tsx; app/src/dashboard/ProgressCharts.tsx; dashboard logic and screen tests.

8

Keep the “not a prediction” message once

Goal: The dashboard stays honest without sounding defensive.

Do: Use one sentence in the dashboard hero: “This is guidance based on recorded information, not an admission prediction.” Keep the screen-reader chart description, but remove the duplicate visible sentence in the stage card.

Check: Read the screen at normal zoom. The idea appears once in visible copy and remains available to screen-reader users.

Likely files: app/src/screens/DashboardScreen.tsx; app/src/dashboard/ProgressCharts.tsx; accessibility tests.

Step 4 - Make search and sign-up lighter

These changes matter, but they should follow the P0 work. The search page already has a clear search field; the sign-in screen is conventional. The goal is to remove extra choices around those core actions.

9

Make search details optional

Goal: Search stays fast and the evidence is still there when someone needs it.

Do: Keep the search field and the mobile Filters button. Move the long “Budget meaning” paragraph into an info toggle beside the budget control. Make the unknown-cost notice a short count with a “Why?” expander.

Check: Search with no filters and with a budget filter. Confirm unknown-cost schools remain visible and the reason is one tap away.

Likely files: `app/src/screens/SearchScreen.tsx`; `app/src/components/UniversityCard.tsx`; search tests.

10

Move the optional photo after sign-up

Goal: Registration feels like account creation, not profile setup.

Do: Keep the required consent, name, email, and password. Remove optional avatar upload from the new-account form and offer it later in Account Profile.

Check: Create-account form has fewer fields. Existing profile photo upload still works after sign-in. Privacy wording and file validation remain intact.

Likely files: `app/src/screens/AuthPrivacyScreens.tsx`; `app/src/auth/AuthProvider.tsx`; auth tests.

Release checklist for every step

CHECK	WHAT “PASS” MEANS
1	Run lint, unit tests, production build, and SSR smoke.
2	Retake 390px and 1440px screenshots for the changed route.
3	Check one keyboard path: open, close, and return focus for any disclosure or widget.
4	Check empty, missing-data, and long-text states. Do not use fake success numbers.
5	Confirm source chips, “not published” labels, and the single guidance disclaimer remain visible where needed.

Recommended next ticket: Step 1 - start the counselor closed on task screens.